



Buddhist AI Ethics Seminar Series 2: Exploring the Intersection of Buddhism and Governance

On August 1, 2024, CamTech University hosted the second installment of the Buddhist AI Ethics Seminar Series, featuring Venerable Dr. San Pisith, a renowned Cambodian Buddhist Monk Scholar. The seminar, titled "Buddhist Governance: Historical and Contemporary Perspectives from Cambodia and Beyond," brought together a distinguished panel of experts to examine the intricate relationships between Buddhism, governance, and modern public theory.

To begin the session, Venerable Dr. San Pisith introduced the concept of Dhammarājā or Dhammikaarājā (ធម្មរាជ ឬ ធម្មិករាជ ឬ ក្សត្រៈបាទធម្មិក), a ruler who embodies the principles of Dhamma, or righteousness, emphasizing compassion, wisdom, and non-violence in governance. This concept is closely linked to the Sangha (សង្ឃ), a community of monks and nuns who follow the Buddhist path. In this context, Dhammarājā or Dhammikaarājā is seen as a leader who embodies the principles of Sangha, working towards the greater good of all individuals and communities. Dr. Pisith emphasized that AI systems can be designed to reflect these principles by incorporating ethical decision-making frameworks that prioritize compassion and non-violence, developing algorithms that promote fairness and transparency, and implementing AI-powered conflict resolution platforms that utilize Buddhist principles such as empathy and understanding.

The concept of Democracy (ប្រជាធិបតេយ្យ) refers to a system where power is held by the people or their elected representatives. Building on this concept, Dr. Pisith explored the potential for Dhammocracy (ធម្មាធិបតេយ្យ) a term coined by combining "Dhamma" with "democracy", a system that combines the principles of democracy with those of Buddhism. This approach aims to create a more just and equitable society through the use of transparent and accountable AI systems that prioritize the well-being of all individuals and communities.

However, it is also essential to consider alternative forms of governance. In addition, Dr. Pisith also explored the concept of Autocracy (អត្តាធិបតេយ្យ), a system where power is held by a single individual or group. While Autocracy may seem antithetical to the principles of Buddhism, which emphasize compassion, wisdom, and non-violence, it is important to recognize that even in Autocratic systems, there are opportunities for leaders to embody these values. For instance, an Autocratic leader may prioritize the well-being of their citizens above personal gain or power. This nuanced understanding highlights the importance of examining governance systems from multiple perspectives.

The seminar also examined the potential benefits of integrating Buddhist values into governance systems across various fields, including architecture, education, and technology. The panel discussion featured experts from various fields, including philosophy, politics, and modern public theory. The discussion highlighted the importance of incorporating Buddhist principles such as compassion, wisdom, and non-violence into decision-making processes, as well as the need for greater transparency and accountability in governance.

The seminar concluded by emphasizing the need for a more compassionate and wise approach to governance in the 21st century. As we navigate the complexities of modern society, we must prioritize empathy, understanding, and cooperation in our decision-making processes. The integration of Buddhist values into governance systems offers a promising approach to achieving this goal. By fostering a culture of mutual respect, cooperation, and understanding within both government institutions and civil society, we can create a more just and equitable society that benefits all individuals and communities.

In conclusion, the Buddhist AI Ethics Seminar Series aims to inspire a new wave of thought leaders who will shape the future of governance through the lens of Buddhist ethics. By exploring the intersection of Buddhism and modern public theory, we can create a more compassionate and wise society that is better equipped to address the challenges of the 21st century. We call upon scholars, policymakers, and practitioners to join us in this endeavor and work together to create a brighter future for all.

